

Trail Rating, Navigation & Signage Playbook

Consolidated system design and implementation roadmap — November 2026

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Executive overview

We are developing a standardized trail rating, navigation, and signage system for Hawk Pride Offroad.

The objective is to make the park easier to navigate, safer to explore, and more intuitive for first-time visitors, without turning the experience into something overly structured or guided.

We are working from the existing CartoTracks map, assuming its trail ratings are accurate. The map is widely considered difficult to read by both staff and customers, and most visitors rely on the GPS-enabled app to understand their location.

Our solution has four fundamental components:

1. A simplified, four-level trail difficulty rating system.
2. A primary navigation network connecting important areas of the park.
3. Three standardized sign types, each with a distinct purpose.
4. A consistent visual language connecting trail signs, markers, maps, and digital navigation.

The system should allow a rider to recognize trail difficulty at a glance, identify where they are, and make their own decisions about where to explore.

Part 1 - The trail difficulty rating system

We are reducing the existing six CartoTracks classifications to four difficulty levels, plus access roads.

HAWK PRIDE TRAIL DIFFICULTY LEGEND



OFFICIAL CLASSIFICATION

Color	Symbol	Classification	Map Key Description
Green	**Circle**	Easy	Maintained dirt, mild grades, small rocks and shallow ruts *Most stock off-road vehicles*
Blue	**Square**	Moderate	Rougher surfaces, steeper grades, rocks, deeper ruts and some technical features *Capable 4WD / UTV • good clearance recommended*
Red	**Diamond**	Difficult	Large obstacles, steep climbs, technical lines, deep ruts and off-camber terrain *Modified vehicles and experienced drivers recommended*
Purple	**Double diamond**	Extreme	Severe climbs, major ledges, boulders and highly technical terrain *Highly modified / purpose-built vehicles and experienced drivers*
Gray / black	**None**	Access Road	General access routes, not part of the difficulty scale

CONVERSION FROM CARTOTRACKS

Existing classification	New classification
1 — Paved or Dirt Road	Access Road
2 — Easy	Easy
3 — Moderate	Moderate
4 — Moderate Hard	Difficult
5 — Hard	Difficult
6 — Extreme	Extreme

Both existing levels 4 and 5 become Red / Difficult.

We will preserve all existing trail identification numbers and names. The conversion does not require us to reassess every trail initially.

IMPORTANT RATING PRINCIPLES

Terrain defines difficulty, not equipment. We will explain what riders should expect on the trail and provide general vehicle guidance, but not require specific tire sizes, lockers, or modifications for particular ratings.

The rating should reflect the hardest unavoidable section under normal conditions. A difficult obstacle with an easy bypass can be identified separately from the easier route.

Equipment guidance belongs primarily on the park legend, map, website, or other reference material rather than on every sign.

Vehicle restrictions, such as ATV-only access, are separate from difficulty. They should be communicated only where applicable.

We will not retain special classification colors for individual trails, such as the discontinued Blue Polaris Outfitter Trail.

Part 2 — The primary navigation network

This is the organizational foundation of the system.

Today, the park contains a large number of interconnected numbered trails without a particularly obvious hierarchy.

We intend to identify a smaller subset of existing trails that will serve as primary navigation routes.

These routes will help riders travel through the park, reach major destinations, and establish a mental picture of how the park connects.

HOW THE NETWORK WILL FUNCTION

Primary navigation routes will:

- Connect major areas and recognizable landmarks.
- Be identifiable through street-style trail signs.
- Appear prominently on the map.
- Provide a useful orientation framework without prescribing where people should ride.

Other trails remain available for exploration and are identified using trail markers.

Not every trail will be part of the primary navigation system.

Importantly, a trail's role as a primary navigation route and its difficulty classification are independent. A primary route can technically have any difficulty rating, although we should ensure practical, accessible connections between essential visitor destinations.

WHAT REMAINS UNDECIDED

We have not yet selected the specific trails that will form the primary navigation network.

This must be determined before we finalize sign locations.

Part 3 — The three sign types

We have established three general navigation sign types. Each communicates difficulty using the same colors, but differently according to its purpose.

TYPE 1 — STREET SIGNS

Purpose: Identify the key trails that make up the primary navigation network.



Standard reflective metal street signs on posts. The entire background color indicates trail difficulty.

Every intersection between primary navigation routes should have the necessary street signs. These are similar to conventional road-name signs.

DESIGN REQUIREMENTS:

- Reflective metal construction.
- Standard street-sign format and mounting hardware.
- Large, high-contrast lettering.
- Trail name and potentially trail number.
- Full sign background colored according to trail difficulty.

A purple street sign identifies an Extreme route even if the double-diamond symbol is absent.

HOW AND WHEN TO USE:

These signs are reserved for the main navigation network, not every trail in the park. These should only be placed at the beginning of main navigation trails and at intersection of main navigation trails.

TYPE 2 — BOARD SIGNS

Purpose: Help riders make navigation decisions at major intersections.

Larger printed, PVC signs containing destinations or trail names with directional arrows.

The color of each arrow communicates its meaning: trail difficulty or general destination.

These are placed at major decision points where someone needs more guidance than a street sign provides.

They may identify individual trails or direct visitors toward locations such as the campground, check-in, or important trail destinations.



DESIGN REQUIREMENTS

Each board should have the trail name, number and difficulty symbol.

- Green = Easy trail
- Blue = Moderate trail
- Red = Difficult trail
- Purple = Extreme trail
- Black = Destination or general wayfinding

HOW AND WHEN TO USE:

At trail intersections - Where to buy

TYPE 3 — TRAIL MARKERS



Purpose: Identify individual trails and help riders confirm they are following the intended route.

Small, inexpensive posts with trail number decals and colored difficulty symbols.

These are the smallest and most numerous elements of the system.

They identify which trail someone is following.

For example, along an Easy trail, a rider encounters green circle markers confirming they remain on that trail.

DESIGN REQUIREMENTS

A typical marker should contain:

- The existing trail identification number.
- The colored difficulty symbol.
- A directional indicator where needed.

The intended placement includes trail entrances, confusing intersections, immediately after major junctions, and places where a route becomes difficult to follow.

The marker is not intended as an expensive miniature street sign. It should be a simple, durable, easily replaceable post and decal system.

WHEN TO USE:

Installed on trail where they are needed for identification, reassurance, and navigation.

Part 4 — Unified visual language

The system is designed so that riders learn one association and recognize it everywhere.

Meaning	Street sign	Board sign	Trail marker	Map
Easy	Green background	Green arrow	Green circle	Green trail line
Moderate	Blue background	Blue arrow	Blue square	Blue trail line
Difficult	Red background	Red arrow	Red diamond	Red trail line
Extreme	Purple background	Purple arrow	Purple double diamond	Purple trail line
Destination		Matching Icon		Destination label/icon
Access Road	Brown	Black arrow		Black/gray road line

The goal is for someone to understand the meaning of a sign without having to stop, consult a legend, or pull out their phone.

The same standards should ultimately be applied across physical signs, printed maps, the website, and digital map experiences.

Part 5 - NAVIGATION ROUTE IDENTIFICATION

Primary navigation routes, such as the Green Line, are separate from the individual trails that make up those routes.

For example, Thompson Trail (#71) is a Moderate (Blue) trail that forms part of the Green Line navigation system.

To distinguish these two concepts, Hawk Pride will use a standardized Navigation Route Badge.

The badge identifies membership in a primary navigation system without replacing or interfering with the trail's existing name, number, or difficulty classification.

CORE PRINCIPLE

Every trail has its own identity and difficulty classification. A primary navigation route is a connected journey through multiple trails.

The signage system must communicate both independently:

- **Trail Number and Name:** Identifies the individual trail.
- **Difficulty Color and Symbol:** Communicates the terrain difficulty.
- **Navigation Route Badge:** Identifies membership in a larger navigational system.

This allows visitors to follow the Green Line while understanding the difficulty of each individual trail they encounter.

DESIGN REQUIREMENTS

- Each primary navigation system will have its own distinctive, named route badge.
- The Green Line will use a green rectangular badge displaying "GREEN LINE" in white lettering.
- The badge must be visually distinct from the green circle used to identify Easy trails.
- Badges will be incorporated into existing street signs, board signs, and trail markers where appropriate.
- Additional navigation systems can be introduced later using the same design convention.

HOW THE BADGE WILL BE USED

Street Signs

On primary navigation trails that form part of the Green Line, a small Green Line badge will accompany the standard street sign. The street sign's background color will continue to represent the difficulty of the individual trail.

Board Signs

Where a board sign directs riders along a trail that forms part of the Green Line, the Green Line badge will appear alongside the trail information and directional arrow.

Trail Markers

Trail markers along the Green Line will display the route badge in addition to the existing trail number and difficulty symbol.

ROUTE CONTINUITY AND DIRECTION

The Green Line is a continuous route that follows multiple existing trails. At intersections where the Green Line changes direction or transitions between trails, directional Green Line markers will indicate which way riders should travel to remain on the route.

These markers will use the Green Line badge with an accompanying directional arrow.

Route identification must follow the actual Green Line path. If only a portion of an existing trail is part of the Green Line, badges and directional indicators should apply only to that portion.